New Supervisors' Guide To Effective Supervision

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Slide Show Notes

Congratulations! You've been promoted to supervisor. It's a big job with important responsibilities.

Today we're going to talk about how you can meet those responsibilities successfully and excel as a supervisor. We'll focus on 14 key areas in which all new supervisors must become fully competent in order to perform their jobs well and prepare for advancement.

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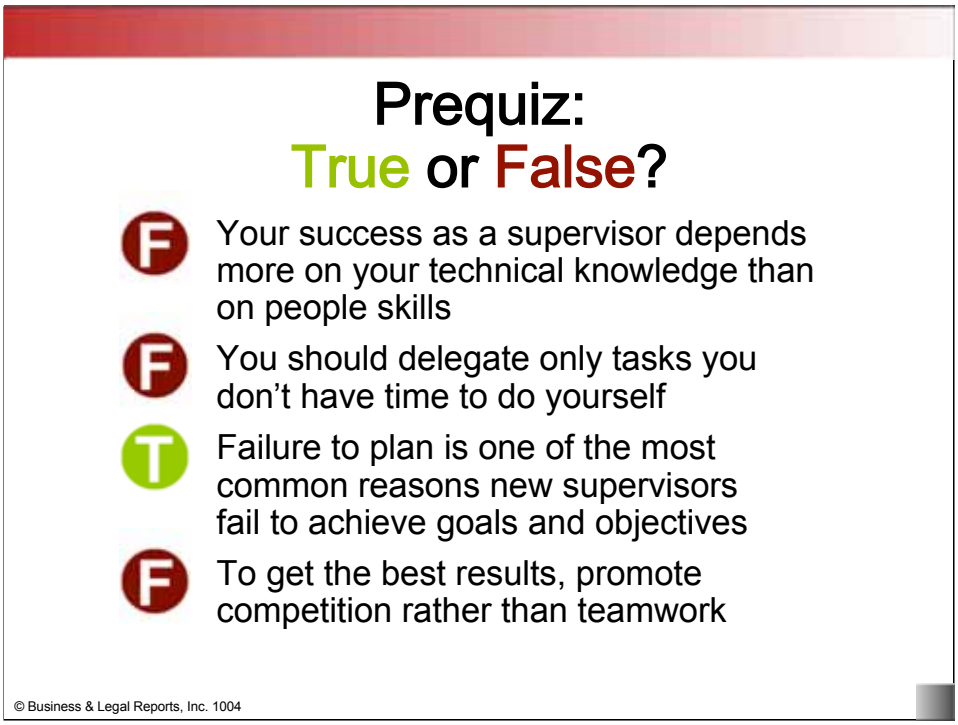
The main objective of this session is to help you be the best supervisor you can be. By the time the session is over, you should be able to:

- Identify key supervisory skills;
- Manage employees effectively;
- Promote superior employee performance;
- Achieve goals and objectives; *and*
- Project a competent, confident, and professional image.



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Before we begin the session, let's take a few minutes to see how much you already know about being a good supervisor. Decide whether each statement on the screen is *true* or *false*. [PAUSE]

Now let's review the answers.

- Your success as a supervisor depends more on your technical knowledge than on people skills—This is *false*.
- You should delegate only tasks you don't have time to do yourself—This is also *false*.
- Failure to plan is one of the most common reasons new supervisors fail to achieve goals and objectives—This is *true*.
- And finally, to get the best results, promote competition rather than teamwork—This is *false*.

How did you do? Did you get all the answers right?

If not, don't worry. You'll learn all about these issues and a lot more during the session.

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For many new supervisors, one of the most difficult parts of assuming their new job is making the transition from being just one of the group to being the leader of the group, from being a buddy to a boss.

- Here is a quote to ponder related to this topic.

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Here are seven basic leadership techniques that you can use to help you make a successful transition from employee to supervisor.

1. Empower employees to feel they "own" their jobs and are responsible for their performance.
2. Use motivation to fuel achievement.
3. Delegate to promote employee growth and responsibility.
4. Make sure employees understand expectations and how to achieve objectives. Then hold them responsible for results.
5. Encourage participation by interacting with employees and asking for input.
6. Use feedback to improve performance and to recognize achievement.
7. Rely more on credibility and trust than on power. Always set a good example, keep commitments, tell the truth, and be fair.

How are your leadership skills? Do you use these seven techniques?

Discuss the importance of leadership and successfully making the transition from group member to group leader.

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Delegation serves several very important purposes. It promotes employee growth and development. It makes the best use of your group's abilities. It promotes participation and builds competence. And it frees you from performing jobs that employees can and should do so that you have time to do the jobs that only you can do.

Delegation is basically a six-step process:

- Decide which tasks to delegate;
- Define the task, outlining what needs to be done, step-by-step;
- Select the right employee for the job;
- Explain the task completely, including the timetable and standards that must be met;
- Provide support and feedback once the employee begins the job, but don't micromanage; *and*
- Follow up to make sure the job has been performed successfully.

Do you use delegation whenever possible? You should. Supervision is largely about delegation.

Lead a discussion about delegation, including when it's appropriate and how to select the right employee for the job.

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Motivation is the driving force behind successful supervision. Motivation helps you guide, encourage, challenge, and engage employees. Although different employees may be motivated by different things, the motivators most often mentioned by employees when surveyed are:

- Good supervision and clear goals;
- Accurate and timely feedback;
- Adequate training;
- Recognition;
- Interesting work that includes challenges and responsibility;
- Growth and advancement opportunities;
- Control over their own work and participation in decision making
- Being part of a team;
- Being informed and being listened to, *and*
- Being treated fairly and with respect.

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- To provide the kind of motivation employees want and need, create a vision that helps employees see how they fit into the big picture.
- Provide clear direction so that workers know the parameters of successful performance, and give lots of feedback and support.
- Have high expectations for all employees. Studies show that high expectations usually result in superior performance.
- Set reasonable, achievable goals, and maintain consistent standards.
- Discover and use personal motivators for each employee.

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Training employees is a big part of any supervisor's job. Whether it's formal classroom training, safety meetings, on-the-job training, or coaching, teaching employees how to do their jobs properly is an important part of your supervisory responsibility.

Training improves worker performance and productivity. Formal and informal training should build skills and competence as well as help employees understand:

- Their responsibilities and functions;
- Tasks and teamwork;
- Equipment and technology;
- Policies and procedures;
- Standards of quality, behavior, and so on;
- How to work safely; *and*
- The legal and regulatory requirements that apply to their jobs.

Think about the training you do and how important it is to you, your employees, and the organization.

Review your employee training programs, indicating training mandated by federal and state regulations.

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To make your training sessions effective:

- Assess employee training needs and match needs to training objectives.
- Set up a practical training schedule that allows for full employee participation.
- Choose appropriate training methods such as classroom training, including discussions, lectures, storytelling, and video; PowerPoint® presentations like this one; other computer-based training, including CD and DVD; demonstrations; and hands-on practice.
- Specify training objectives so that employees know what they're supposed to learn.

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Here are some more tips to make your training effective:

- Write a well-organized training outline that presents subject matter in a logical order and emphasizes the most important points.
- Incorporate interactive methods into training, like asking questions or solving problems.
- Provide helpful handouts that highlight training points.
- Plan for questions and answers during and at the end of the training session.
- Evaluate learning with a quiz or practical performance test.

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New employee orientation is a special kind of training. It's important to get new workers off to a good start. A good orientation can reduce employee failure and turnover. It can also help new employees feel welcomed into the group and the organization, understand the job, and learn about the organization and its policies.

You can conduct orientation by yourself or appoint an experienced employee to take the new worker under his or her wing for a few weeks until the new employee is settled into the job.

During a new employee's first day or two on the job, you should:

- Introduce the employee to other workers;
- Show the employee around, including the location of locker room, restrooms, lunchroom, emergency exits, and equipment, tools and supplies, and so on;
- Describe the employee's job and duties;
- Describe the department's role and responsibilities;
- Cover basic rules such as safety rules and procedures such as reporting absences and emergencies; *and*
- Identify an employee who can answer questions in your absence.

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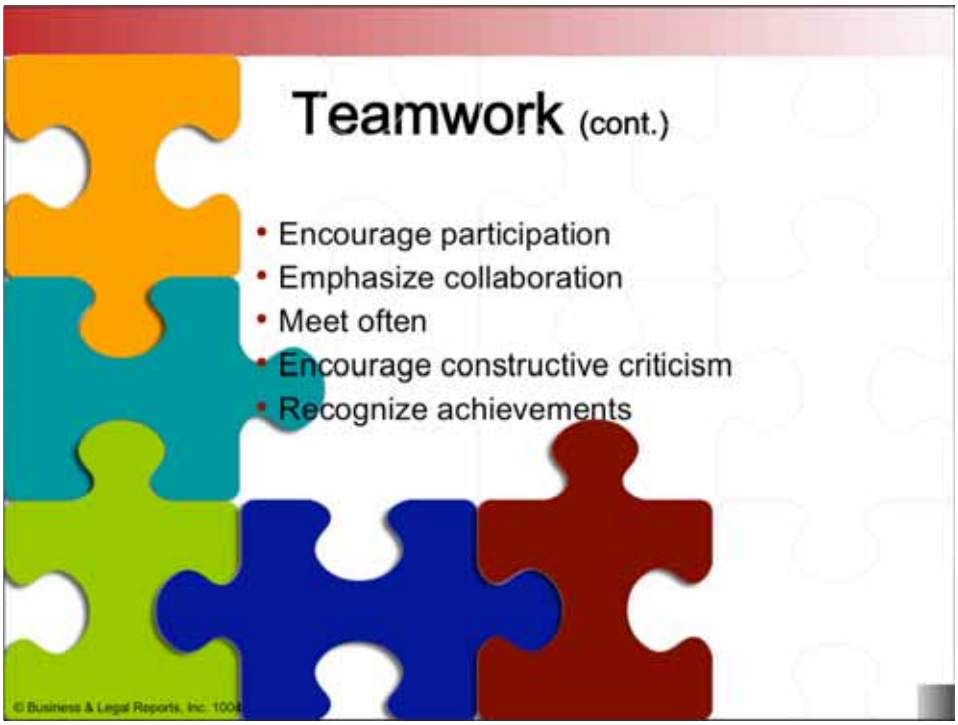
Teamwork allows you to make the most of the diverse skills and perspectives among your employees. To build an effective team, remember these teamwork essentials:

- Require a professional attitude based on courtesy and mutual respect among team members;
- Encourage team members to express different points of view;
- Make each team member feel valued and appreciated for his or her contributions;
- Explain goals and expectations, clearly communicating quality and productivity standards;
- Encourage feedback to make sure that everyone understands team goals;
- Cultivate a sense of belonging and acceptance, and show concern for individuals; *and*
- Set a good example by demonstrating your commitment to the team and its goals.



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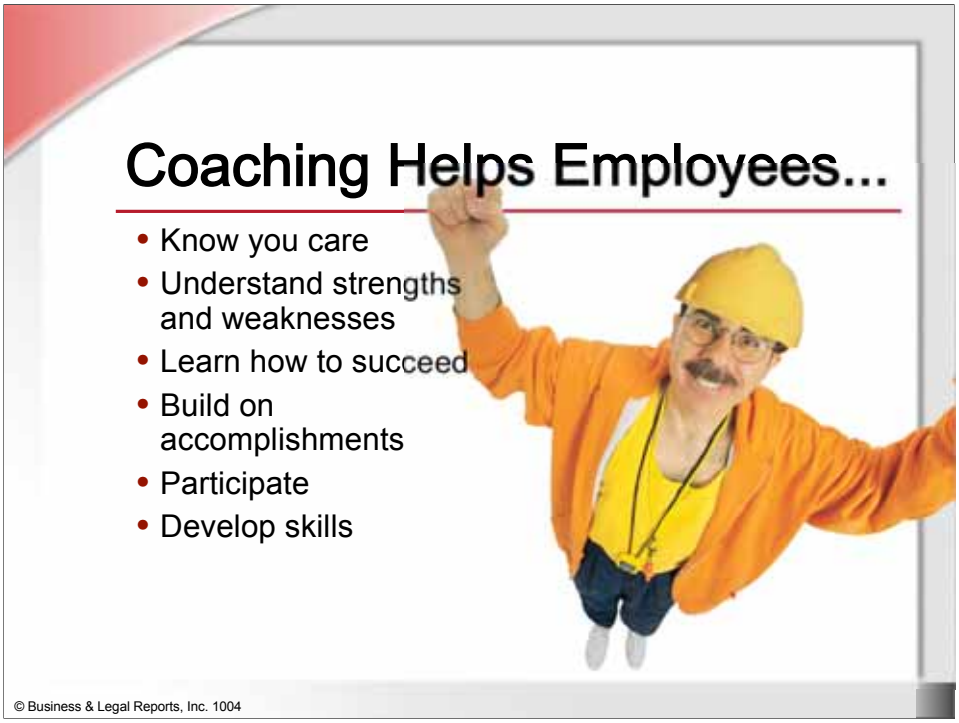
To build strong teams, you also need to:

- Encourage participation and suggestions from all team members;
- Emphasize collaboration over competition, and reinforce team-oriented behavior and encourage team members to cooperate with one another and share information, ideas, and expertise;
- Meet often with your team and allow adequate time for group discussion;
- Encourage constructive criticism and provide plenty of feedback and guidance; *and*
- Recognize both individual and group achievement. Let the team know that contributions will be recognized in performance appraisals.

Have you been using these strategies to build strong teams? Teamwork can deliver some truly outstanding results.

Lead a discussion about the importance of teamwork. Discuss opportunities for employees to work together. Also talk about some of the results teamwork has achieved in your organization.



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Every team needs a coach, which means coaching is another important supervisory responsibility. Coaching helps employees:

- Know that you care about them;
- Understand their strengths and weaknesses;
- Learn how to improve performance and succeed in their jobs;
- Build on their accomplishments;
- Participate and contribute more; *and*
- Develop skills and confidence.

Coaching benefits all employees and improves morale and job satisfaction. All employees need personal attention and guidance so that they know you support their efforts and value their contributions. The nature of your coaching may differ from employee to employee, however. For example, struggling workers need specific help in mastering skills and encouragement in their efforts.

Average performers, on the other hand, need direction in setting and reaching higher goals. And top performers need recognition and challenges to maintain their level of achievement.

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In order to encourage the best possible performance from each employee, you need to focus on three specific areas—performance goals, performance measurement, and performance appraisal. We'll begin by talking about goals.

Performance goals define for each employee what's expected in terms of accomplishments, growth, and contributions to the organization. They also provide a fair means of evaluating individual performance and an objective basis for determining rewards, training needs, and advancement.

To be effective, performance goals must be:

- Objective;
- Written in clear terms;
- Measurable;
- Observable;
- Achievable, though challenging;
- Prioritized;
- Flexible enough to allow for change; *and*
- Developed and agreed to by you and the employee.

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Measuring employee performance makes appraisals more objective and useful as well as indicates where improvement is needed.

- When you measure effort:
  - Focus on how work was performed;
  - Define work behaviors clearly, then observe and document;
  - Encourage employee development; *and*
  - Recognize that the employee may have little control over results.
- When you measure results:
  - Focus on accomplishment of goals or responsibilities;
  - Clearly define the desired results;
  - Document actual results; *and*
  - Recognize that the worker has control over and impact on results.
- When you measure knowledge:
  - Focus on technical or educational competence;
  - Make sure knowledge attained applies to the job; *and*
  - Recognize that knowledge can't be the only criterion for judging employee performance.

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A fair, thorough performance appraisal lets employees know how they're doing by:

- Setting standards;
- Measuring performance against the set standards;
- Linking rewards and discipline to performance;
- Recognizing achievements and progress; *and*
- Identifying improvement goals, action plans, and timetables.

To achieve these important objectives, you must plan for performance appraisals by reviewing each employee's job description, performance goals, and performance measurement documentation.

When you complete the appraisal form, make sure your assessment is objective and relates solely to job performance and behavior that affects performance.

Be sure to provide appraisal information to the employee before the appraisal meeting so that the employee can prepare for the meeting and think about new performance goals.

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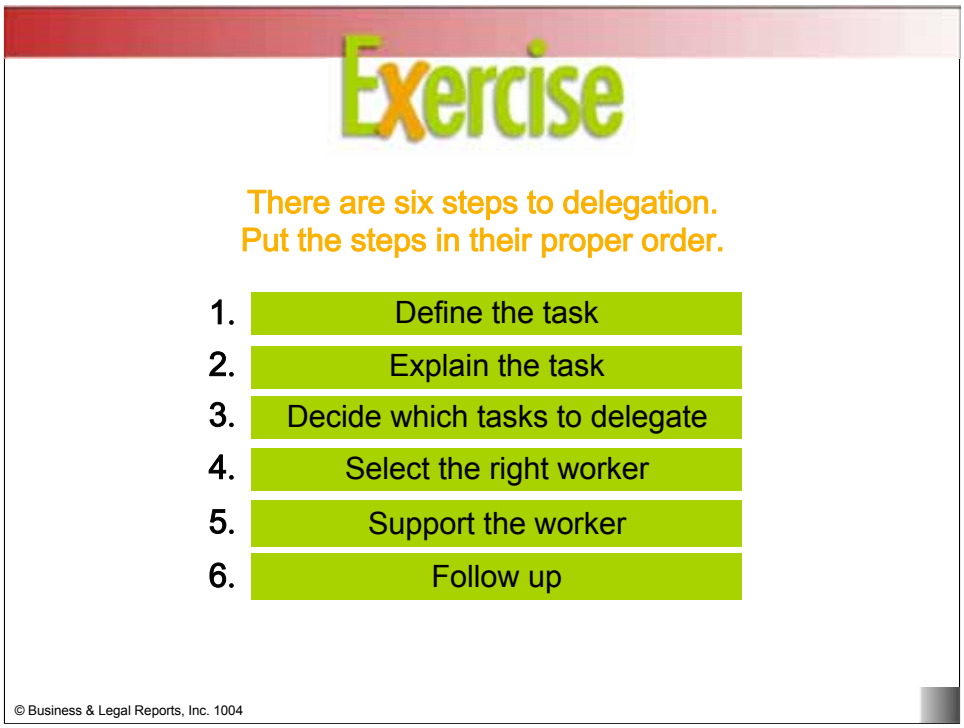
Conduct the appraisal meeting as a structured dialogue. In other words, you run the meeting, but the employee's input, questions, and assessments are important to the process and must be taken into account. Explain that the purpose of the appraisal is to review performance objectively in terms of stated goals, to recognize areas of success as well as areas in need of improvement, and to develop a plan for continued improvement. Also explain how the appraisal relates to pay increases and other rewards.

- Start the performance review on a positive note with accomplishment and strengths. Praise the employee for achievements.
- Then move on to areas that need improvement. Be specific when talking about performance that needs improvement, and give specific examples.
- Ask for the employee's input, and listen carefully to the employee's response.
- Agree on new performance goals, an action plan for achieving those goals, and a timetable for carrying out the action plan.
- Finally, have the employee sign the appraisal form.



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It's time now for an exercise. Earlier in the program we talked about delegation and how important it is in supervision. Now let's see if you remember the six steps we talked about. They are on the screen, but they're not in the right order. See if you can figure out the proper order. [PAUSE]

Let's see how you did. The correct order is:

- Decide which tasks to delegate;
- Define the task;
- Select the right employee for the job;
- Explain the task to the worker;
- Support the employee with advice and assistance; *and*
- Follow up to make sure the job is completed successfully.

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Now it's time to ask yourself if you understand the information that has been presented so far. For example, do you understand what we've said about the connection between effective supervision and:

- Leadership?
- Delegation?
- Motivation?
- Training and orientation?
- Teamwork and coaching?
- Employee performance?

It's important to understand all this information, since knowledge and competence in each of these areas of supervision has a direct impact on your success as a supervisor.

Answer any questions trainees have about the information presented in the previous slides.

Conduct an exercise, if appropriate.

Let's continue now to the next slide and talk about another critical supervisory skill—communicating effectively.

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Good supervision requires good communication. Communication between you and your employees, colleagues, and managers improves the flow of vital information and improves working relationships.
To ensure successful communication, remember these tips:

- Think about what you want to say before you speak;
- Organize your thoughts into a logical sequence;
- Consider your expectations and think about the results you need to generate;
- Use conversational language;
- Be respectful and courteous to subordinates and superiors alike;
- Be precise, using concrete language and examples;

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- Be concise and say only what needs to be said to get your point across;
- Present instructions in a step-by-step format;
- Use positive language, and restate key points for emphasis;
- Explain why, not just what, whenever possible; *and*
- Listen to what others have to say.

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One particular type of communication that is very important in supervision is feedback. To be sure your feedback is constructive and productive:

- Make it specific and base it on a specific event, act, or behavior;
- Describe what was done well and/or what could be improved;
- Give feedback as soon as possible after the incident or behavior;
- Consider the employee's feelings and focus on the performance, not the person;
- Use positive feedback both to praise and to correct performance;
- Be helpful—let employees know what you expect and how to achieve it; *and*
- Limit feedback to one aspect of performance at a time.

Think about the impact your feedback has on your employees and how you can use positive feedback to improve employee performance.

Ask trainees to give specific examples of how and when they use feedback, and how their feedback helps improve employee performance.

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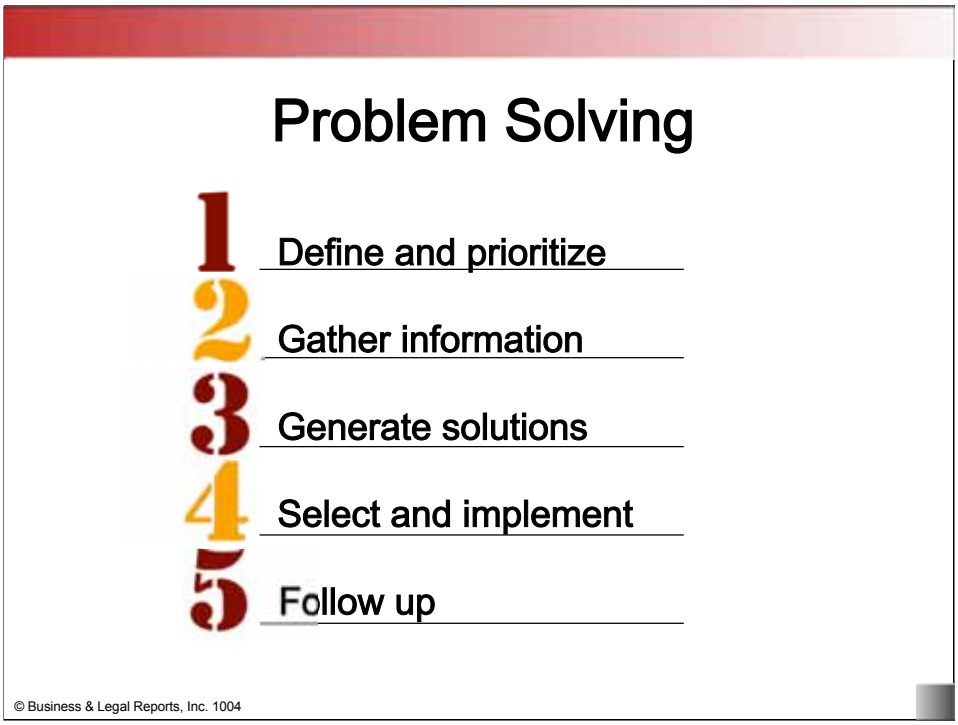
One of the most often-cited reasons new supervisors don't succeed is that they fail to plan effectively. In order to meet goals and objectives, you need focused, accurate, and complete plans.

- Develop long-term plans to meet broad goals that cover the next 3 to 6 months. Sit down with paper and pen or use your computer to outline goals, desired results, and completion dates. Then list the steps required to reach each long-term goal. You should have a plan for each major goal as well as an overall plan that includes all long-term goals and timetables. You should also identify benchmarks you'll use to track progress and success.
- In addition to long-term planning, you also have to develop short-term plans to deal with more immediate objectives that cover the next few days or weeks. Draw up weekly and daily plans as appropriate. Include the steps to be followed to achieve each short-term objective and the key employees involved. Check to make sure that all the necessary resources will be available, including labor, equipment, and materials.

Of course, whenever you're making plans—long- or short-term—you must accept that plans may have to change because of changing circumstances. So be flexible and be prepared to remake your plans.



Slide Show Notes

Problems are an aspect of your job with which you are no doubt already very familiar. Every supervisor faces problems every day. Solving problems is a big part of your job. It's important to identify problems early and take prompt action before they get out of hand. Here's a simple five-step process for solving problems.

- One, define and prioritize problems. Make sure you understand what the real problem is and how serious it is. Problems with the most serious consequences get top priority.
- Two, gather information about the problem to understand it better.
- Three, generate possible solutions. There's usually more than one way to fix a problem. Draw on previous experience or the experience of colleagues who have dealt with similar problems. Ask yourself, "What if we did this?" or "What if we did that?"
- Four, select the best and most efficient solution and implement it.
- And five, follow up to make sure the problem is really solved. Some problems may require a second look before you finally solve them.

Do you take a step-by-step approach to problem solving?

Discuss the importance of identifying and solving problems quickly and effectively. Give some examples from your own experience.

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There never seems to be enough time to get done all you need to get done every day. That's why managing your time efficiently is so important. Here are some suggestions that can help.

- Identify priorities at the beginning of each workday and workweek;
- Use a PDA, calendars, and to-do lists to better manage your time;
- Allow more time than you think you need for each task on your list;
- Be flexible and revise your daily and weekly to-do lists as you go along; *and*
- Take advantage of your prime time—that's the time of day you're the most focused and energetic—to get important work done.

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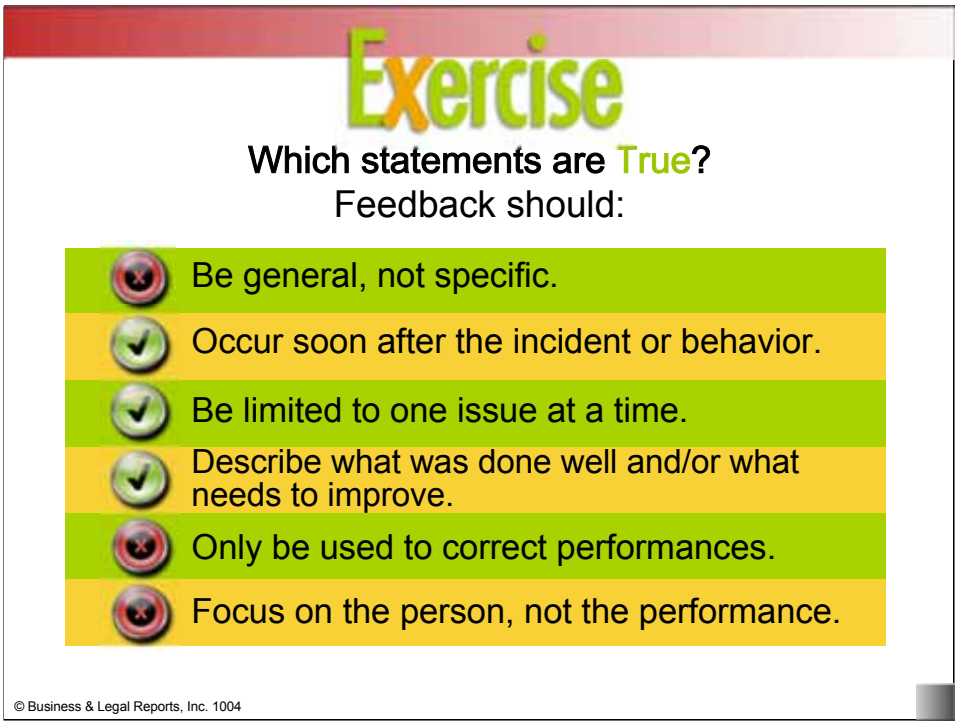
- Manage phone and e-mail communications effectively;
- Rely on e-mail and voice mail as much as possible for communications to minimize interruptions;
- Try to deal with each piece of paper coming across your desk effectively, handling it as few times as possible;
- Set limits on interruptions when you're busy;
- And finally, focus on doing the things only you can do and delegate the rest.



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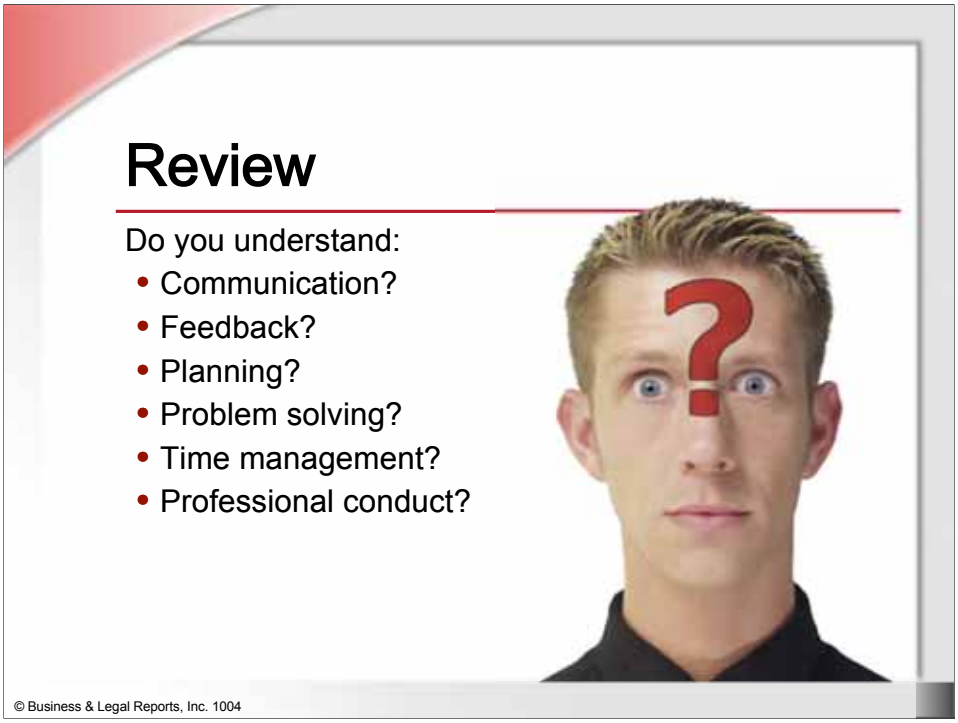
Feedback is very important in shaping employee behavior and improving performance. On the screen you see a number of statements about feedback. Some will be *true*; others will *not*. Can you figure out the *true* statements? [PAUSE]

Let's see how you did.

- Feedback should be general, not specific—This is *not* true.
- Feedback should occur as soon as possible after the incident or behavior in question—This is *true*.
- Feedback should be limited to one issue at a time—This is *true*.
- Feedback should describe what was done well and/or what needs to improve—This is also *true*.
- Feedback should only be used to correct performances—This is *not* true.
- And finally, feedback should focus on the person, not the performance—This is *not* true.



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Let's take a moment now to review the information presented in the previous slides. Do you understand what we've said about:

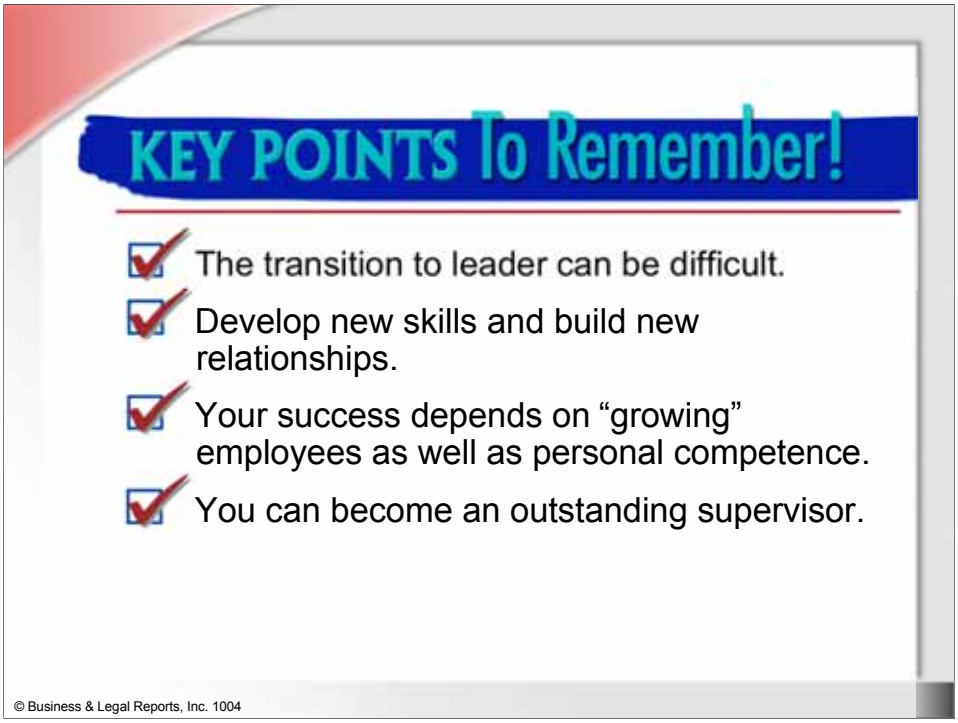
- Communication?
- Feedback?
- Planning?
- Problem solving?
- Time management?
- Professional conduct?

You need to understand and use all of this information to be an effective and successful supervisor.

Answer any questions trainees have about the information presented in the previous slides.

Conduct an exercise, if appropriate.

Now let's go on to the last slide and some key points to remember.



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Here are the main points to remember from this session on new supervisor competencies:

- Making the transition from member of the group to leader of the group can be difficult.
- You need to develop a variety of new skills and build new relationships.
- Remember that your success depends on "growing" employees as well as on developing greater personal competence.
- With time, effort, and experience, you can become an outstanding supervisor.

This concludes the New Supervisors' Guide to Effective Supervision training program.

Give trainees the quiz, if appropriate.